



Textual Evidence Detectives

Grade 7 • North Carolina • Reading

RL.7.1

Cite several pieces of textual evidence to support analysis of explicit statements and inferences drawn from a literary text. An 80-minute block-period packet with warm-up, guided practice, partner discussion, independent practice, small-group work, and a full answer key.

PRINT • TEACH • REVISIT



Plan the 80-minute block

Level and alignment

Grade 7 · North Carolina · Reading; RL.7.1 — Cite several pieces of textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly as well as inferences drawn from the text.

What is included

Cover; teacher guide; vocabulary and lesson preview; original passage; warm-up (2 items); guided practice with organizer (4 items); partner discussion (3 items); independent practice (6 items); small-group intervention and enrichment (4 items); exit ticket; complete answer key; access and sources page.

Suggested pacing (80 minutes)

Warm-up 8 min · passage + guided practice 25 min · partner discussion 12 min · independent practice 20 min · small-group work 10 min · exit ticket 5 min.

Preparation

Print student pages separately from the answer key. Review the passage and organizer before class. No outside novel or paid app required.

Student directions

Read the passage carefully. Use evidence from the text to support every answer. Quote or closely paraphrase the text and name the paragraph.



Before you read

Key vocabulary

Lesson focus

Explicit evidence is stated directly in the text. An inference is a reasonable conclusion built from evidence plus what you already know, not a guess. Strong analysis usually needs more than one piece of evidence. Quote the text or closely paraphrase it, and name the paragraph.

Model 1 — Paragraph 2 says Mr. Alvarez "checked the mailbox three times before noon." What can you infer, and what is your evidence?

You can infer he is anxious about the letter. Evidence: checking three times before noon shows repeated, unusual attention to something he is waiting for.

Model 2 — Is "the garden had tomatoes" an inference or explicit evidence if paragraph 1 states it directly?

Explicit evidence — the text states it directly, so no inference is required.



WARM-UP

Warm-up · Before you read

Answer using what you already know. Five minutes.

1. What does paragraph 2 state explicitly about Mr. Alvarez's morning?

2. What can you infer about why he checked the mailbox repeatedly? Cite evidence.



The Last Season

1. Mr. Alvarez had taught seventh grade for thirty-one years, and for the last twelve of them he had kept a community garden behind the school with his students. Tomatoes climbed a lattice of old broom handles. Bees moved between rows of marigolds planted to keep pests away.
2. On the first Tuesday in October, he checked the mailbox three times before noon. Each time he walked back to his classroom a little slower than before.
3. "The district sent a letter about the garden lot," he told his fourth-period class, setting an unopened envelope on his desk. He did not open it. He asked a student to water the tomatoes instead, then stood at the window for the rest of the period.
4. At lunch, two students, Priya and Deshawn, found him kneeling by the marigolds, pulling weeds that were not really there. "You already did that row," Priya said. He looked at his hands, dirt-streaked, and laughed quietly. "Habit," he said.
5. That afternoon he finally opened the letter in front of the class. He read it twice, silently, before speaking. "They are selling the lot next spring. A parking structure." His voice stayed level, but he set the letter down instead of folding it.
6. Deshawn asked if the garden could move. Mr. Alvarez said maybe, if a new plot could be found before spring, but plots that size were hard to come by near the school. He did not promise anything.
7. For the rest of the week, he brought his classes outside every day instead of the usual twice. He photographed the tomatoes, the bent broom handles, the bees. On Friday he pinned the photographs to the class bulletin board under a hand-lettered sign: "Twelve seasons. Keep looking."



Guided practice · Evidence organizer

Work through this organizer together before independent practice.

It Says Quote or closely paraphrase the text.	It Means Explain the evidence in your own words.	And So State the inference or analysis it supports.

1. What explicit action shows he avoided the letter in paragraph 3?

2. What can you infer from him standing at the window for the rest of the period? Cite evidence.

3. What explicit detail shows Priya noticed something odd about his weeding?

4. What can you infer about Mr. Alvarez's state of mind from the weeding detail in paragraph 4? Cite two pieces of evidence.

Partner discussion

Discuss each question with a partner before writing a joint response.

1. What does the text state explicitly about how he read the letter in paragraph 5?

2. What can you infer from him setting the letter down instead of folding it? Cite evidence.

3. What explicit fact does the letter contain?

Independent practice

Work independently. Cite evidence from the text in every answer.

1. What can you infer about how certain a new garden plot is? Cite evidence.

2. What explicit change does Mr. Alvarez make in paragraph 7?

3. What can you infer about why he photographs the garden that week? Cite evidence.



Independent practice

Work independently. Cite evidence from the text in every answer.

4. What does the bulletin board sign state explicitly?

5. What can you infer the sign means, using evidence from the story?

6. Cite two pieces of evidence that Mr. Alvarez cares deeply about the garden.



Small-group work

Use with students who need additional support.

1. Cite evidence that the students notice his mood shift, and explain the inference it supports.

2. Why might the author choose not to have Mr. Alvarez cry or raise his voice? Use evidence to support your inference.

Small-group work

Use with students ready for additional challenge.

1. Is it explicit or an inference that the garden will definitely close? Explain using the text.

2. Combine two pieces of evidence to support the inference that Mr. Alvarez is trying to give students a lasting memory of the garden.

Exit ticket

Answer independently to show what you learned today.

1. Write one full inference about Mr. Alvarez, with two pieces of cited evidence supporting it.



Exit ticket · self-assessment

Rate today's work:

4 — I can teach this to someone else.

3 — I can do this independently.

2 — I can do this with help.

1 — I need to revisit this with my teacher.



Answer key

1. He checked the mailbox three times before noon.
2. He was anxious about a letter he was expecting; checking three times before noon (paragraph 2) shows unusual, repeated attention to the mail.
3. He set it on his desk unopened and had a student water the tomatoes instead of doing it himself.
4. He was distracted or worried; paragraph 3 states he stood at the window instead of teaching or working, right after avoiding the letter.
5. She said, "You already did that row."

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

6. He was distracted and not fully present; evidence includes pulling weeds that were not there and repeating a row Priya says he already did.
7. He read it twice, silently, before speaking.
8. He was troubled by the news; paragraph 5 notes his voice "stayed level, but he set the letter down instead of folding it," suggesting composure that does not match his actions.
9. The district is selling the garden lot next spring to build a parking structure.
10. It is uncertain; paragraph 6 states he said "maybe" and that he "did not promise anything," and that plots that size were hard to come by.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

11. He brings his classes outside every day instead of the usual twice.

12. He wants to preserve a record of the garden before it may be gone; this follows immediately after learning the lot will be sold, and he photographs specific, familiar features like the tomatoes and broom handles.

13. "Twelve seasons. Keep looking."

14. It likely means the garden's value continues even if its future is uncertain, and students should keep noticing what is around them; this follows the deliberate act of photographing and displaying twelve years of the garden.

15. He has kept it for twelve years (paragraph 1), and he photographs it and makes a bulletin board display after learning it may close (paragraph 7).

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

16. Priya comments on his repeated weeding (paragraph 4); this supports the inference that his distress is visible enough for students to notice.
17. It suggests he manages difficult feelings quietly; the text explicitly says his "voice stayed level" even while his actions (setting down the letter, pulling nonexistent weeds) reveal distress.
18. It is not fully certain — the letter states the lot will be sold, which is explicit, but paragraph 6 explicitly says finding a new plot is only a "maybe," so the story leaves the final outcome open.
19. He brings classes outside daily instead of twice (paragraph 7) and photographs the garden's features, then displays them with a sign about continuing to look — together these actions suggest he wants the garden remembered even if it closes.
20. Answers vary; require a stated inference plus two specific, correctly cited details from the passage that reasonably support it, not just restated events.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Access, sources, and license

AIG

Ask for a second interpretation, a counterexample, or a student-written item at the same rigor, with an explanation of the choice.

504

Follow the individual plan: extended time, breaks, enlarged print, reduced copying, or an alternate response method as documented.

EC

Pre-teach key vocabulary before reading. Model the first guided-practice item aloud. Accept oral or dictated responses when appropriate.

ESL

Preview key vocabulary with examples. Allow brief home-language discussion before independent writing. Provide sentence starters for open-response items.

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NC ELA Standard Course of Study, Grade 7: <https://www.dpi.nc.gov/documents/publications/catalog/>

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